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Googlebombed!



GOOGLE, THE WORLD'S favourite search engine, is vulnerable. And ironically, this is because of its proprietary software that ranks pages based on their popularity, rather than any other parameter. *Discover* magazine wrote how the search engine's software could be manipulated to get your results on top. It is euphemistically called Googlebombing, and it is now fast becoming big business.

Excerpts from the piece:

Does Google have a favorite in the upcoming presidential election? Not Google's CEO or its charismatic young founders, not the shareholders of the company-Google, the search engine itself. Does it favor one candidate over the other?

This is not a preposterous question. Just type the words miserable failure as a search query, and see the top result. The document that Google thinks is most relevant is a biography of the 43rd President of the United States, George W Bush.

Before some of you write angry letters to the editor about the liberal bias infecting search engines, consider this: The results for "miserable failure" were not directly shaped by anyone at Google. Instead, Web users manipulated the rankings by altering their own Web pages. The practice is called Googlebombing.

This kind of group intervention is possible because of the ingenious way that Google calculates its search results, a much-scrutinized system called PageRank. It involves two known variables.

If you search for a relatively common word like paleontology, you'll find hundreds of thousands of pages that contain the word. A search engine is not much use unless it finds the most valuable pages and returns them as the top results. Theoretically, Google could have hired thousands of humans to read all the pages in its index—instead, the company tapped the free labor of all the people in the world who were already creating Web pages.



Most Web pages have hypertext links to other Web sites. Google's software recognizes those links as votes. The PageRank system tallies all the votes for every page it has found on the Web. Pages that have attracted more

links become more prominent in Google's rankings. When you query "paleontology" the top 10 are the 10 pages that have received the most links.

Apart from the votes system: let's say you create a link from your page to a site devoted to the life of baseball great Willie Mays. Google pays attention to the words you use to describe the site. If you link to the Mays site with the phrase "Barry Bonds's godfather," Google learns to associate the phrase with that site, even if it doesn't mention Barry Bonds. If enough people on the Web publish the same link with the same phrase, eventually Google will serve up the Mays site as the top result for "Barry Bonds's godfather."

Read the entire story at <http://snipurl.com/googlebombing>

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